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OPERATIONS CONSULTING

FREE RESOURCE

The 90- Day Pre- Opening Blueprint

The checklist used with every client, reimagined as a premium printable guide for restaurant and hospitality operators moving from blank floor plan to opening night.

FOR RESTAURANT & HOSPITALITY OPERATORS

By Leander Mena

Fractional F&B Operations Leader, Miami

This elevated edition pairs the original framework with a modern dark editorial layout, gold accents, and founder-led presentation styling.

30+ page framework Operational checklists

Opening week playbook





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INTRODUCTION

About this blueprint

START AT DAY -120

This framework was built over 18 years and 15+ restaurant openings across Miami, from Michelin-chef concepts to luxury hotel F&B. It was the backbone of operations at Maska Indian Kitchen + Bar, which opened on schedule, achieved a 4.7+ opening week, and delivered 26% labor by week three.

It also reflects banquet revenue recovery work at SLS Brickell, where revenue improved 31% in 90 days. Every item in this checklist has been tested, refined, and stress-tested under real opening-night pressure.

“If you don’t get the first 30 days right, every later fix becomes more expensive.”

OPERATING PRINCIPLE

How to use this blueprint

1. **Start at Day -120** or wherever the project currently sits.
2. **Assign an owner** to every deliverable.
3. **Use the weekly scorecard** to track progress and weak spots.
4. **Flag risks early**; a fix at Day -30 costs far more than the same fix at Day -90.

Foundation

Days -120 to -90

CONCEPT BEFORE SPEND

“If you don’t
get this right,
everything
else is
expensive
band-aids.”

WEEK 1-2

Concept clarification

- Finalize concept statement in 25 words or less
- Define target guest persona: demographics, psychographics, occasion
- Lock menu direction with chef or culinary lead
- Confirm price point strategy: check average and high-low range
- Establish brand voice and service style: casual, polished, experiential
- Create mood board for interior, plating, and uniform direction
- Sign off on floor plan with kitchen flow analysis

WEEK 3-4

Financial framework

- Build 24-month P&L projection: conservative, base, optimistic
- Set opening budget cap and contingency, with 15% buffer preferred
- Define labor cost target by month 3, 6, and 12
- Establish food cost target and vendor negotiation strategy
- Create pre-opening cash flow model through break-even
- Secure funding or investor sign-off on budget
- Set up accounting system and chart of accounts

WEEK 5-6

Legal & permits

- File for business entity: LLC, Corp, etc.
- Apply for EIN
- Submit liquor license application immediately
- Submit food service license application
- Schedule health department pre-inspection walkthrough
- Confirm zoning compliance for seating, signage, and hours

- Review lease terms for TI allowance, kick-out clauses, and key money
 - Secure general liability, property, and workers' comp insurance
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FOUNDATION CONTINUED

WEEK 7-8

Team architecture

- Build organizational chart with all positions and reporting lines
- Define salary bands and total compensation for every role
- Draft offer letters and employment agreements
- Create hiring timeline showing when each role must be filled
- Identify key hire risks for hard-to-fill roles in the local market
- Set up payroll system: Gusto, ADP, or equivalent
- Design benefits package where applicable

PHASE 1 CHECKPOINT

Before moving to buildout

The concept, budget, licenses, org chart, and opening labor targets should already be clear before procurement starts. This is where operator confidence is earned: every later decision gets easier when the business model is already disciplined.

“Clarity
compounds.
Chaos
compounds
faster.”

PRE-OPENING OPERATING TRUTH

Buildout & procurement

Days -90 to -60

MARGIN DECISIONS HAPPEN HERE

“The decisions made here determine your operating margins for the next three years.”

WEEK 9-10

Vendor matrix & negotiation

- Issue RFPs to at least three vendors per category
- Protein: beef, poultry, seafood
- Produce
- Dry goods and pantry
- Beverage: alcohol and non-alcohol
- Linens and uniforms
- Smallwares and equipment
- Cleaning and chemicals
- Score vendors on price, reliability, quality, delivery, terms, backup, certifications, and relationship
- Negotiate payment terms: Net 30 minimum, Net 45 ideal
- Lock order quantities and delivery schedule
- Establish a backup vendor for every critical category
- Set up vendor file with contacts, account numbers, and cutoff times



BUILDOUT CONTINUED

WEEK 11-12

Equipment & smallwares

- Finalize kitchen equipment list with chef
 - Order long-lead items: custom hoods, walk-ins, specialty equipment
 - Purchase smallwares: pots, pans, utensils, thermometers
 - Order POS system and test integration
 - Set up reservation system: Resy, OpenTable, Tock
 - Purchase uniforms and approve samples
 - Order menu boards, signage, and wayfinding
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WEEK 13-14

Menu engineering

- Finalize recipes with exact specs: yield, portion, plating
 - Cost every menu item to the penny
 - Run theoretical food cost analysis with 28–32% target for full-service
 - Design menu layout with eye-tracking principles
 - Price using competitor analysis plus cost and perceived value
 - Identify high-margin stars and low-margin dogs
 - Create modifier and upsell strategy
 - Build allergen matrix and dietary accommodation protocol
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WEEK 15-16

Tech stack

- Configure POS with full menu, modifiers, and pricing
 - Set up inventory management system
 - Configure reservation platform with table map
 - Set up online ordering if applicable
 - Configure payroll and scheduling software
 - Set up CRM or guest database
 - Create email marketing account: Klaviyo or Mailchimp
 - Set up Google Business Profile and social accounts
-

People & process

Days -60 to -30

TEAM BEFORE LAUNCH

“You can fix a broken plate. You can’t fix a broken team on opening night.”

WEEK 17-18

Hiring sprint

- Post all remaining positions
- Conduct interviews with a structured scorecard, not gut feel
- Check references for every management hire
- Extend offers with clear start dates
- Schedule pre-opening training calendar
- Order training materials and handbooks
- Plan a “meet the team” event for culture-building

WEEK 19-20

SOP development

- Write opening procedure: who unlocks, what time, checklist
- Write closing procedure: cash out, cleaning, security
- Write server sequence of service
- Write line cook prep standards
- Write inventory management SOP
- Write guest recovery protocol
- Write cash handling and tip pooling policy
- Write health and safety compliance checklist



PEOPLE & PROCESS CONTINUED

WEEK 21–22

Training program

- Build a two-week training curriculum
- Day 1–2: Culture, mission, tour, introductions
- Day 3–4: Menu knowledge; taste every dish, know every ingredient
- Day 5–6: Service standards and role-specific skills
- Day 7–8: POS training and mock orders
- Day 9–10: Shadow shifts and feedback loops
- Day 11–12: Team service practice and mock service
- Day 13–14: Soft opening prep and final assessments
- Create training manual: digital and printed
- Schedule trainer assignments and plan daily huddle talking points

WEEK 23–24

Soft opening plan

- Set soft opening dates: 3–5 nights, limited covers recommended
- Create invite list: friends, family, industry, media
- Design feedback collection system: digital survey + manager table touches
- Plan menu for soft opening: full menu or limited version
- Set comp budget for soft opening
- Schedule post-soft-opening debrief meetings
- Create social media content calendar for opening buzz

Final sprint

Days -30 to opening

ELIMINATE, DON'T ADD

“The last 30 days are about elimination, not addition.”

WEEK 25-26

Pre-launch checks

- Final health department inspection walkthrough
- Fire department inspection and certificate of occupancy
- Liquor license final approval and posted
- All permits displayed visibly
- POS fully programmed and tested with dummy transactions
- Music licensing secured: ASCAP, BMI, SESAC
- Final equipment calibration: ovens, fryers, refrigeration temps
- Emergency contact list posted: plumber, electrician, HVAC, exterminator

WEEK 27-28

Staff readiness

- All staff hired and onboarded
- Uniforms distributed and fitted
- Schedule published through opening week
- All staff pass menu knowledge test: 80% minimum
- Mock service completed with full team
- Identify weak performers and assign extra coaching
- Confirm opening-night staffing levels with 20% overstaffing



FINAL SPRINT CONTINUED

WEEK 29-30

Opening week execution

- Day -7: Final deep clean of the entire space
- Day -6: Inventory delivery and storage organization
- Day -5: Staff walkthrough of every station
- Day -4: Friends & Family night #1 at 50% capacity
- Day -3: Friends & Family night #2 at 75% capacity
- Day -2: Final team meeting, role assignments, pep talk
- Day -1: Rest. No work. Leader needs to be sharp.
- Day 0: Opening night

OPENING WEEK PLAYBOOK

Daily rhythm

PRE-SERVICE

- Manager walkthrough: lighting, music, temperature, cleanliness
- Line check: every station, ingredient, and temp
- Pre-shift huddle: 10 minutes, 3 priorities, 1 focus
- POS test: one test transaction per terminal
- Reservation review: VIPs, occasions, dietary notes

DURING SERVICE

- Manager floor presence, not office presence
- 2-minute table touches on every table
- Kitchen timing checks every 15 minutes
- Real-time feedback collection: verbal, not formal
- Social media content capture with guest permission

POST-SERVICE

- Team debrief: what worked, what didn't, one fix for tomorrow
- Revenue reconciliation and cash deposit
- Prep list for tomorrow
- Manager log entry
- Thank-you message to VIPs or media

Weekly scorecard & red flags

USE EVERY MONDAY

The weekly scorecard

Track these metrics every Monday morning to catch drift before it becomes a launch problem.

METRIC	TARGET	WEEK 1	WEEK 2	WEEK 3	WEEK 4
Covers / Night	-				
Average Check	\$____				
Labor Cost %	< ____%				
Food Cost %	< ____%				
Guest Complaints	0				
5-Star Reviews	> ____%				
Staff No-Shows	0				
Menu Item 86'd	< 2/night				

Red flags - when to pause and fix

1. **Health inspection failure** - do not open. Period.
2. **Less than 70% of kitchen team hired by Day -30** - push opening date.
3. **Food cost theoretical above 35%** - re-engineer menu before printing.
4. **No backup vendor for protein** - single-source protein is a shutdown risk.
5. **POS not tested with real transactions** - opening night is not a test environment.
6. **Chef hasn't tasted final menu with full team** - menu knowledge gap becomes service failure.
7. **No guest recovery protocol** - one bad opening-night experience can live forever online.

Founder profile

MIAMI-BASED OPERATOR



Leander Mena is a Fractional F&B Operations Leader based in Miami, Florida. With 18+ years opening, stabilizing, and scaling hospitality operations, he specializes in pre-opening leadership, operations recovery, and fractional GM support for restaurants and hotel F&B teams.

Trusted by: Maska Indian Kitchen + Bar, SLS Brickell, Marabu Restaurant, Viceroy Miami, Accor Properties, and SLS Hotels & Resorts.

Services: Fractional General Manager engagements, pre-opening leadership from 60–120 days, and operations recovery sprints from 30–90 days.

PRE-OPENING LEADERSHIP

OPERATIONS RECOVERY

FRACTIONAL GM

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This blueprint is provided for educational purposes. Every operation is unique. Adapt the framework to your concept, market, and team. For hands-on support, book a discovery call at www.leandermena.com.

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